

It was not a particularly dark night and the weather was especially upbeat. I leaned over Atul's shoulder as he flicked open the sleek, black case and triumphantly exhibited the six-stringed beauty. It was a Fender! It took a dedicated application of my secret agent training to muffle my excitement and broadcast it as a nonchalant grin. "Plug it into the amp", said he. I plugged the beauty into the home-made 400 W beast, which drove my Sony speaker set, the showpiece of my computer system. A riff, a strum and away it went, taking the speakers with it. "Must have been the OP-Amp, I had to compromise with its specs", the wannabe engineer put in. Right. To market, to market,

to buy a set of speakers...Armed with cash and a spring in my step (new gadget up ahead!), off I went.

I started with a small shop that had the knack of disappearing into its surroundings when viewed at a particular angle. The keeper was adamant that I buy the Adcom 660 W Multi-media Speaker—a 2.1-channel speaker set. The asking price was a shade over Rs 600 and I was intrigued. The set had reasonable bass output, but the treble lacked the aural nuance I was looking for. My next run-in was with an even cheaper unit, a Mercury 440 W that alas was only stereo. Mercury speakers are affordably priced and are hot sellers and I could tell that the set would be



■ If you are into music only, a good 2.1 speaker set will serve you well

■ Always test the speakers you buy on your music—take a CD or tape with you and test the speakers using your music

■ When you buy a multi-channel speaker system, make sure that your sound-card has the correct outputs

■ There are some THX and Dolby Digital certified speaker sets available in the market—look for these if you want to set up a home theatre

Speak easy

Agent 001 goes out on a hunt for a replacement set of speakers after blowing up his original set



an ideal buy for a desktop setup where music makes a sporadic appearance. The shop also exhibited a two-piece Philips system, rated at 600 W and priced at Rs 699. An elder sibling from the same company packed a 1000 W punch, called itself the Philips Fun Power Plus and was Rs 1,295 away from a purchase. None enticed me however, not even the Rs 750 Creative SBS15, another stereo set. These were all good systems, with output ranging from very decent to pretty good, but the punch that I was looking for was missing.

So on I went, bravely venturing into the my-wallet-feels-lighter territory. Three sets greeted me on this side of the market. The Aztec (rated at a cool 2000 W), the Creative Inspire 2.1 (12 W RMS subwoofer and 4.5 W RMS satellites) and the Cambridge SW320 (12 W RMS subwoofer and 4 W RMS satellites). Priced equally at Rs 2,500, my vote went to the Cambridge set for its wonderful sound reproduction (the bass, especially) but the set lacked the multiple-channel support and the inputs that I was looking for. Dejected, but neither shaken nor stirred, I pointed to the Creative 4.1 speaker set that nestled in the corner. At Rs 4,150, the set seemed like a nice compromise between price and performance.

Logitech is doing great things in the speaker segment, a vendor told me, pointing to the Soundman Extrusio DSR-100, an 800 W, 4.1 set that was priced Rs 12,000. He also told me that the Z560, a 400 W, THX certified, 4.1-channel speaker set was expected to arrive any time soon. Patience was never my forte and I settled for a Jetway Artis 5.1 unit, a Rs 12,000 set code-named X8L/5. It has discrete inputs for all the channels and the requisite plugs where the Fender could find port—all in all, a perfect fit. Though my wallet is lighter, my ears ring with pleasure. ■